

A Palestinian woman argues with an Israeli soldier while being held at gunpoint in the West Bank town of Hebron. After clashes between Palestinians and Israeli security forces, the army imposed a curfew on the town in December 1996.

the towns, cities and refugee camps and the Israelis closed the border crossings between Israel and the occupied territories. They did this so as to seal their borders and prevent suicide bombers slipping through. But it also meant that Palestinians could not cross into Israel where many of them worked by day. This increased unemployment and hardship amongst the Palestinians. It also hurt the Israeli economy because many Israeli farms and factories depended on a plentiful supply of cheap Palestinian labour.

Despite these setbacks, talks between the Israeli government and the PA were still held, often in neutral, foreign countries. Agreements were made to withdraw Israeli troops from more Palestinian towns and cities on the West Bank and, in return, Arafat agreed to arrest Hamas militants. But, time and time again, it was the extremists on both sides who dominated the headlines. And it was not always Jew versus Arab or Arab versus Jew.

Key question
Why was Rabin assassinated?

Key date
Assassination of Rabin: 1995

The assassination of Rabin 1995

In November 1995, 150,000 Israelis gathered in Tel Aviv for a peace rally. The main speaker was the Prime Minister, Yitzak Rabin, who had signed the peace deal in 1993. After the rally, a young Israeli, Yigal Amir, stepped up and shot Rabin, who died on the way to hospital. The assassin was a member of an Israeli group that opposed any peace with the Palestinians. This group believed that the West Bank (which they called Judea and Samaria, as in the Bible) was part of the Land of Israel, the land which God had promised to the Jews. In their view, Rabin had been prepared to give away parts of the sacred Land of Israel and was thus a traitor and an enemy of the Jewish people. At his trial, Amir said: 'When I shot Rabin, I felt I was shooting a terrorist.' He was sentenced to life imprisonment.